

Involving customers

Everyone is creative—and that includes the end users of your innovation. Users are not simply passive consumers of new products or services; they will have plenty of ideas about how they would like to improve or change what they are using.

TIP**LISTEN TO COMPLAINTS**

Pay attention to negative reactions from test users. If they reject your idea, it may not be worth pursuing.

Appreciating user involvement

An important theme in managing innovation is learning to work with users as co-creators of innovation ideas, for two good reasons. First, their ideas can help make a better innovation, and second, if you involve them they will buy into the idea. These users do not have to be limited to customers—the same applies to process innovation. Changes to the way people work can tap into their ideas about how the process should improve. Otherwise, they may find ways to resist the change. There are two ways of encouraging these ideas—appealing to specific users who are likely to contribute, and encouraging contributions from the entire user base.

Asking the best users

Focus groups identify users and their interests as an input to innovation design, and, later, as a sounding board. Prototyping and test marketing let you observe users' reactions to new ideas, and allow them to add their own. Lead-user methods help you identify early adopters among your user base, to help shape your idea while you develop it. Finally, communities of practice are small, often volunteer, groups of users that use innovative solutions on a continuing basis, such as the Linux community, music software groups like Propellerhead, and Apple's i-platform devices group.